ITALY · ROME, LAZIO

Rome

4 Day City Break

DESTINATION	DURATION	IDEAL FOR
Italy, Rome, Lazio	4 days	2–4 people

YOUR JOURNEY

Expedition Route

Italy · Rome, Lazio · 4 days

DAY 1
Vatican City · Castel Sant'Angelo · Trastevere

DAY 2
Colosseum · Roman Forum · Palatine Hill · Capitoline Hill

DAY 3
Pantheon · Piazza Navona · Trevi Fountain · Spanish Steps

DAY 4
Galleria Borghese · Villa Borghese · Baths of Caracalla

JOURNEY HIGHLIGHTS

- The Vatican Museums and Sistine Chapel, with Michelangelo's ceiling in its full monumental scale
- The Colosseum and Roman Forum as they were meant to be read, without rushing
- An afternoon at the Galleria Borghese, home to the finest Bernini sculptures in the world
- Ancient Rome on foot: the Colosseum, the Roman Forum and Palatine Hill in a single unhurried morning
- Rome's baroque fountains and piazzas: the Pantheon, Piazza Navona and the Trevi Fountain
- The Baths of Caracalla, an imperial bathhouse on a scale that still defies comprehension

DAY 1

The Vatican, Castel Sant'Angelo & Trastevere

Start early at the Vatican Museums; book the first available entry slot and arrive at opening. Allow two hours for the galleries, moving through the Gallery of Maps and the Raphael Rooms before the corridors lead into the Sistine Chapel. Exit directly into St Peter's Basilica, where the interior is larger than photographs suggest. Climb the dome for the finest view over Rome. In the afternoon, descend to St Peter's Square and read the full scale of Bernini's colonnade from ground level. Walk across the Tiber via the Ponte Sant'Angelo, its ten angel statues designed by Bernini, to reach the Castel Sant'Angelo, Hadrian's mausoleum converted into a papal fortress. In the evening, cross the river into Trastevere, Rome's best-preserved medieval neighbourhood, as the restaurants open and the alleys fill with light.

- Vatican Museums. One of the world's great art collections, with the Gallery of Maps and the Raphael Rooms.
- Sistine Chapel. Michelangelo's ceiling fresco (1508–12), a defining work of Western art.
- St Peter's Basilica. The world's largest church; the dome offers the highest panorama over the city.
- Castel Sant'Angelo. Hadrian's mausoleum, later converted into a papal fortress on the bank of the Tiber.
- Trastevere. Rome's most intact medieval neighbourhood, best explored on foot after dark.

INSIDER TIP

Book Vatican Museums tickets online; walk-up queues can exceed two hours in peak season. The recommended approach is to take the first entry slot, visit the Gallery of Maps first, the Raphael Rooms second, and time the Sistine Chapel for when the morning rush thins. St Peter's Basilica entry is free; dome access has a separate charge. In Trastevere, start at Piazza Santa Maria in Trastevere and walk southeast from there.

DAY 2

The Colosseum, Roman Forum, Palatine Hill & Capitoline Hill

Start as early as possible. The Colosseum must be reached before mid-morning and timed entry must be booked in advance. The arena floor has been accessible to general ticket holders since 2023 and should not be missed. From the Colosseum, walk directly into the Roman Forum, the civic and religious centre of ancient Rome; the ruins are most legible with a basic site map. The Arch of Titus, the Temple of Saturn, the Via Sacra: the scale of what once stood here becomes clear on foot. Continue uphill to Palatine Hill, the highest and oldest of Rome's seven hills, with imperial palace ruins and views directly down into the Forum. In the afternoon, walk northwest to Capitoline Hill, where Michelangelo designed the piazza in 1536, and the twin Capitoline Museums, which hold the finest Roman sculpture collection in the world. Descend to Piazza Venezia. In the evening, walk north to the Pantheon area; the piazza reads quite differently at night, when the crowds thin and the building reclaims its mass.

- Colosseum. The Flavian Amphitheatre, completed in 80 AD and the largest amphitheatre ever built.
- Roman Forum. The civic heart of ancient Rome, with the Arch of Titus, the Temple of Saturn and the Via Sacra.
- Palatine Hill. The legendary founding hill of Rome, with palace ruins and views over the Forum below.
- Capitoline Hill. A Michelangelo-designed piazza with the world's finest Roman sculpture collection inside.
- Piazza Venezia. The geographical centre of modern Rome, with the Altar of the Fatherland.

INSIDER TIP

Book Colosseum tickets as far in advance as possible; slots are released 30 days ahead and sell out quickly. Palatine Hill is included with the Colosseum ticket and is usually less crowded than the Forum. The Capitoline Museums are closed on Mondays. The roof of the Altar of the Fatherland (Vittoriano) has free elevator access and offers one of Rome's finest panoramas, almost always overlooked.

DAY 3

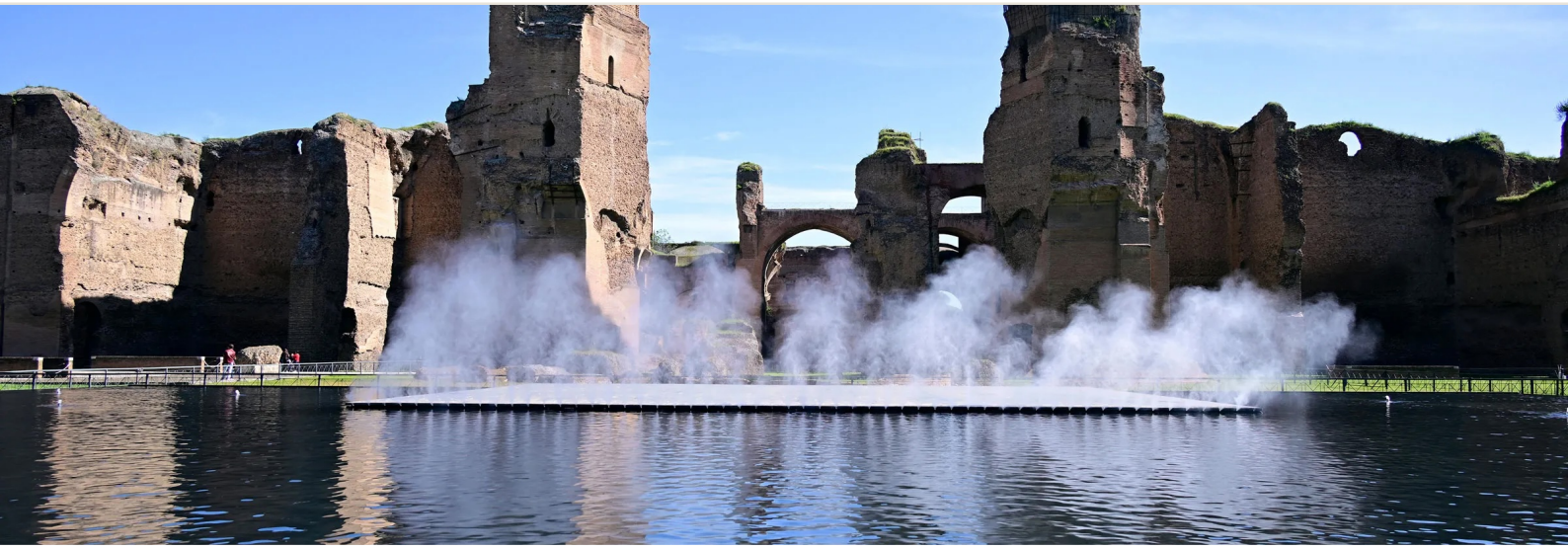
Pantheon, Piazza Navona, Trevi Fountain & the Spanish Steps

Begin at the Pantheon, and go before nine. Rome's most perfectly preserved ancient building, now a church, is entirely free to enter. The oculus at the crown of the dome is 8.7 metres in diameter, open to the sky, and the only source of natural light inside. Walk north to Piazza Navona, built over the footprint of Domitian's stadium, with Bernini's Fountain of the Four Rivers at its centre. In the afternoon, walk northeast to the Trevi Fountain, the largest and most theatrical of Rome's baroque fountains, completed by Nicola Salvi in 1762. Continue north to the Spanish Steps, the 135-step staircase linking Piazza di Spagna to the hilltop church of Trinità dei Monti, with views back across the roofline. The lanes of the historic centre are best explored on foot in the evening; follow the maze between Campo de' Fiori and Via del Corso for aperitivo as the city moves into its evening register.

- Pantheon. Built in 125 AD, the best-preserved Roman building in the world, with an oculus open to the sky.
- Piazza Navona. Rome's finest baroque piazza, built over Domitian's stadium, with Bernini's Four Rivers fountain at its centre.
- Trevi Fountain. Rome's largest baroque fountain, completed by Nicola Salvi in 1762.
- Spanish Steps. The 135-step staircase from Piazza di Spagna to the hilltop church of Trinità dei Monti.
- Historic centre at dusk. Campo de' Fiori to Piazza della Rotonda for the evening aperitivo circuit.

INSIDER TIP

The Pantheon now charges an admission fee; confirm the current rate locally. Go before 9am to experience it before the crowds arrive. The Trevi Fountain is most photogenic at dawn or after 10pm, when the tour groups have cleared. The Spanish Steps are least crowded in the early morning or late at night. Campo de' Fiori operates as a fresh produce market until around 2pm and as a social piazza from evening onwards.



DAY 4

Galleria Borghese, Villa Borghese & the Baths of Caracalla

Rome's fourth day moves deliberately. The morning belongs to the Galleria Borghese: Bernini's Apollo and Daphne and Pluto and Proserpina, and Canova's reclining Pauline Borghese, all within a single baroque villa in the middle of a city park. Entry is strictly timed to two-hour slots and should be booked several weeks ahead. After the gallery, walk through the Villa Borghese gardens, Rome's most central park, elevated above the surrounding streets. Follow the Viale delle Magnolie to the Pincio terrace for the view over Piazza del Popolo and the roofline to the south. In the afternoon, cross to the Aventine Hill for the Giardino degli Aranci, an orange garden on a terrace above the Tiber with one of Rome's finest and least-visited panoramas: the dome of St Peter's framed between umbrella pines. Later in the afternoon, descend to the Baths of Caracalla, the vast imperial bathhouse completed in 216 AD, built for over 1,600 bathers at once, its vaulted halls still standing at their original height.

- Galleria Borghese. Bernini's Apollo and Daphne and Pluto and Proserpina, and Canova's Pauline Borghese.
- Villa Borghese. Rome's most central large park; walk to the Pincio terrace for views over Piazza del Popolo.
- Giardino degli Aranci. The Aventine orange garden, with a terrace view of St Peter's dome framed in pines.
- Baths of Caracalla. The imperial bathhouse of 216 AD and one of the best-preserved Roman structures in the city.

INSIDER TIP

Galleria Borghese must be booked in advance through the official gallery website; same-day availability is rarely possible and the two-hour limit is strictly enforced. The Giardino degli Aranci is free and almost entirely unknown to first-time visitors; it is the finest free viewpoint in Rome. The Baths of Caracalla are at their best in the late afternoon, when the angle of the light enters through the broken vaults.

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